

01

THE PROBLEM OF RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Master verdict: A personal creator is not necessary for religion, but some disciplined orientation to ultimacy, transformation, community and soteriology is needed to prevent the category from becoming empty.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Fact: Recent 2025–2026 scholarship and reviews continue to discuss religious naturalism as an attempt to retain awe, value, ritual and community within a naturalistic worldview. □□ Inference: This strengthens the conceptual question whether supernatural belief is necessary for religion, but it does not displace the syllabus’s primary evidence: Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Master verdict: A personal creator is not necessary for religion, but some disciplined orientation to ultimacy, transformation, community and soteriology is needed to prevent the category from becoming empty.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: recent 2025–2026 scholarship and reviews continue to discuss religious naturalism as an attempt to...

ANSWER LINE: □ Mnemonic — “Religion = the 3 D’s minus God: Discipline, Dharma, Deliverance.” A religion can offer a path, ethics and liberation without a creator deity — Buddhism is the proof.

02

FUNCTIONAL AND SUBSTANTIVE CRITERIA OF RELIGION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Ninian Smart’s dimensions: religion has doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social & material dimensions — belief in a creator God is not on the essential list. □ A functional definition: religion = a way of life orienting one toward ultimate meaning, liberation, and the transcendent/absolute — which need not be a personal God. □□ Hence “religion without God” is coherent: the sacred/ultimate ≠ necessarily a deity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that religion has doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social & material dimensions — belief in...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: religion has doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social & material dimensions — belief in...

ANSWER LINE: Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

03

BUDDHISM AS A NON-THEISTIC RELIGION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Non-theistic: the Buddha was silent/agnostic on a creator God (the avyākata — unanswered questions); the world runs by pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) and karma, needing no creator. □ Yet fully a religion: it has the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, ethics (śīla), meditation, the Saṅgha, and a soteriology (nirvāṇa — liberation from dukkha). □ What replaces God: the Dharma (law/teaching) and the goal of nirvāṇa — an impersonal ultimate.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

(Later Mahāyāna develops quasi-devotional Buddha/Bodhisattva figures, but the core is non-theistic.) □□ Verdict: Buddhism decisively shows religion does not require God. □.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: (Later Mahāyāna develops quasi-devotional Buddha/Bodhisattva figures.

ANSWER LINE: Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

04

WESTERN CRITIQUES OF THEISTIC RELIGION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Marx: religion = “the opium of the people” — a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation; it will dissolve with a just society. □ Freud: religion is an illusion, a wish-fulfilment / cosmic father-projection.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

His critique targets religion AND its morality together. □ □□ Ownership note: the printed 2025 Q5(c) — “Present an account of Nietzsche’s criticism of religion and morality” — is owned by Religion and Morality §9.6, because the stem couples religion with morality.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

This file retains Nietzsche as a critique of theistic religion and as the bridge to post-theistic value — §9.4 — and does not duplicate the ownership.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: religion = “the opium of the people” — a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation.

ANSWER LINE: Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

05

AGNOSTICISM, ATHEISM AND SUSPENSION OF JUDGMENT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Nietzsche: “God is dead... and we have killed him.” □ Marx: religion is “the opium of the people.” □ Feuerbach: God is the projected essence of man — “theology is anthropology.” □ Buddhist: the world runs by dependent origination — no first cause/creator needed. □□ Huxley (coined “agnostic”): God’s existence is unknown/unknowable.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Nietzsche: “God is dead... and we have killed him.” □ Marx: religion is “the opium of the people.” □ Feuerbach: God is the projected essence of man — “theology is anthropology.” □ Buddhist: the world runs by dependent origination — no first cause/creator needed. □□ Huxley (coined “agnostic”): God’s existence is unknown/unknowable.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should...

ANSWER LINE: Agnosticism (Huxley): the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should suspend judgement (distinct from atheism, which denies God). □ Relation of religion & God for the agnostic: an agnostic may still value religion’s ethical/experiential dimensions while withholding assent on God — supporting a non-theistic or minimal religiosity. □□ Kant’s practical faith and Spencer’s “Unknowable” are agnostic-adjacent positions.

06

RELIGIOUS PRACTICE, MEANING AND COMMUNITY WITHOUT GOD

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

How do agnostics relate religion & God?” (2023) → §4 + §9.5. [Concept] “Is belief in God essential to religion?” (2018, 2020, 2021) → §1 + §2 + §9.1. [Cārvāka] “Cārvāka’s critique of belief in suprasensible entities.” (2025, 10m) → §9.6 — the vyāpti argument is the answer, not the hedonism. [Theist’s denial] “How would a religious person deny the possibility of religion without God?” (2019, 15m) → §9.1 + §11 — argue the theist’s case properly before rebutting it. [Mīmāṃsā] “Can ritual religion function without a deity?” → §9.7 (apauruṣeya + apūrva). [Modern] “Can a naturalist be religious?” → §9.8 (Dewey, Dworkin, fictionalism).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

How do agnostics relate religion & God?” (2023) → §4 + §9.5. [Concept] “Is belief in God essential to religion?” (2018, 2020, 2021) → §1 + §2 + §9.1. [Cārvāka] “Cārvāka’s critique of belief in suprasensible entities.” (2025, 10m) → §9.6 — the vyāpti argument is the answer, not the hedonism. [Theist’s denial] “How would a religious person deny the possibility of religion without God?” (2019, 15m) → §9.1 + §11 — argue the theist’s case properly before rebutting it. [Mīmāṃsā] “Can ritual religion function without a deity?” → §9.7 (apauruṣeya + apūrva). [Modern] “Can a naturalist be religious?” → §9.8 (Dewey, Dworkin, fictionalism).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that how do agnostics relate religion & God?” (2023) → §4 + §9.5. [Concept] “Is...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: how do agnostics relate religion & God?” (2023) → §4 + §9.5. [Concept] “Is...

ANSWER LINE: [Buddhism] “State & evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.” (2024, 20m) → §2 + §9.2. [Nietzsche] “Nietzsche’s criticism of religion and morality.” (2025, 10m) → □□ primary owner is Religion and Morality §9.6; use §3/§9.4 here only for the post-theistic bridge. [Agnosticism] “What is agnosticism?

07

OBJECTIONS, COMPARISONS AND EXAM VERDICT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A non-theistic religion may retain soteriology, ritual, ethics, authoritative teaching and a sacred orientation while rejecting creator-God theism.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Religious functions are supplied by a path, community, authoritative teaching, ethical discipline and liberation goal rather than by divine command or creation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The category of religion becomes broader than theism, though critics question whether a non-personal ultimate can sustain worship, dependence and obligation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not equate non-theism with atheistic materialism or assume that the absence of a creator God removes every sacred or transcendent commitment.

ANSWER LINE: God is sufficient for many forms of religion but not conceptually necessary for every religion, as Buddhist traditions demonstrate through non-theistic soteriology and disciplined practice.